

news feed

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hypothesis

MPEG-4

■ What is it?

A wide range of audio and video technologies designed to heavily compress streams of video, only with an interesting twist.

■ What does it do?

It allows video and audio to function just like a Web page, giving you the chance to interact with various elements of the picture in real-time. Imagine clicking on an actor's suit and finding all the details about it, like how much it costs and where to buy it.

■ What's the potential?

MPEG-4 is catching up with developers and television broadcasters are lining up to cash in on the amazing possibilities of interactive video. With the interest it's garnering, MPEG-4 is set to become the most revolutionary compression standard yet.

snapshot

\$17.7 bn
was the worldwide
gaming software
revenues in 2001
Expected revenues
by 2004:
\$21.6 bn

Source: Datamonitor

Beach office

Have you dreamed about working while sitting on the beach with a cool drink by your side? Well, it's already happening at Telenor, a Norwegian telecom company.

Telenor's latest office at Oslo's former airport has what is claimed to be Europe's largest wireless network. The office happens to

be by the seaside of Fornebu—employees are found with laptops by the seaside in the evenings!

With this arrangement, workers are on the network no matter where they are in the company and are able to work efficiently. Telenor chose this system because of cramped office space—so cramped that they use a 40x40 centimetre cupboard for storage!

Telenor is also trying to sell this wireless zone concept to other companies. Could this be the beginning of the office of the future? Perhaps.



ILLUSTRATIONS: Prashant

4G on the horizon

3G will take a lot more time to become commonplace. But NTT DoCoMo has already started work on a fourth generation (4G) network.

NTT has major plans for 4G and it is expected to be around 260 times faster than 3G. This translates into downlink speeds of up to 100 Mbps and uplink speeds of 20 Mbps.

The most attractive feature of these handsets is

high-definition video—they will have pictures with double the resolution of normal television. Prototypes using this technology are slated to be released this summer and DoCoMo has plans of launching the network around 2010.

All this is happening despite the fact that DoCoMo's two-year-old 3G network is not yet in place properly and is currently only available in Tokyo.



Smart Dust

Imagine small modules the size of dust particles, which can act as sensors with communication capabilities. This is nanotechnology and it's nearer than you think.

The 'Smart Dust' has been developed by researchers of the University of California at Berkeley. These are basically self-sustaining network nodes with sizes of less than a millimetre each. They have in-built sensors and can communicate with other devices. This makes it possible for Smart Dust to be used in the field of distributed processing, health, security, etc, opening up endless technological possibilities.

Open source robots

The latest entrant in the robot scene is Open Pino, whose technical details are open source.

Open Pino (named after Pinocchio) is developed by Kitano Symbiotic Systems Project, which is funded by the Japanese government. The group has put the entire technical details (software as well as hardware) online. The source code of Pino is available under GPL (GNU Public License).

Priced at \$7,500 per kit, the Japanese claim that Pino sales have picked up since its online advertising started.